We use modal verbs to show if we believe something is certain, probable or possible (or not).

We also use modals to do things like talking about ability, asking permission.

They ***may come*** by car.

Impossibility

We use the negative can't or cannot to show that something is not possible.

That ***can't be*** true.

You ***cannot*** be serious.

We use ***couldn't/could not*** to talk about the past.

We knew it ***could not*** be true.

He was obviously joking. He ***could not*** be serious.

Probability

We use the modal ***must*** to show we are sure something to be true and we have reasons for our belief.

It's getting dark. It ***must be*** quite late.

You haven't eaten all day. You ***must be*** hungry.

Permission

We use ***can*** to ask for permission to do something.

Can I ask a question, please?

Can we go home now?

could is more formal and polite than *can*

Could I ask a question please?

Could we go home now?

Instructions and requests

We use ***could you*** and ***would you*** as polite ways of telling or asking someone to do something.

Can I ...? Can you ...? Could I ... Could you ...? and so on.

The ***negative*** form is ***can't*** in spoken English and ***cannot*** in written English.
We sometimes say ***cannot***, but it is very ***emphatic.***
The negative form of could is ***couldn't*** in spoken English and ***could not*** in written English.
We sometimes say ***could not.***
We use ***can*** and ***can't.***

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